

details about the best flights and trains to get there, and also have a listing of the tour operators within the state.

An easier way of getting information is through Yahoo! or MSN Travel. Both the portals give customised information about all the different aspects of a holiday such as planning, hotels, maps, cruises, transportation. These sites give you planned tours, options to make your own tours, flight and train information and reservation facilities. MSN has even tied up with Cox and Kings and Expedia to give you some of the best deals.

If you are putting together a trip, sites such as www.indianrail.gov.in can be very useful. Though you cannot book the tickets online, it does help to know the availability, departure and arrival time and the fares. Indian Airlines (<http://indian-airlines.nic.in>) and Jet Airways (www.jetairways.com), both allow booking of tickets online. These sites can be scoured for good deals with cheaper rates for night flights and so on. The same can be done for international sites such as Air India (www.airindia.com), Cathay Pacific (www.cathaypacific.com), British Airways (www.britishairways.com), Kuwait Airways (www.kuwait-airways.com) and Gulf Air (www.gulfairco.com).

If you are planning a destination overseas, the sites most travellers swear by are the Lonely Planet [\[et.com\]\(http://www.lonelyplanet.com\) and Expedia \[www.expedia.com\]\(http://www.expedia.com\). The Lonely Planet will give you a detailed description for any destination of your choice—all you have to do is click on a country, and the site reveals its places of historical interest, its main tourist attractions, the best time to visit and the political scenario.](http://www.lonelyplan-</p>
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In the event of a long vacation involving numerous destinations, try the TripPlanner. You simply have to pick out the destinations on your itinerary and you will get the estimated costs of the air tickets involved. The TripPlanner gives you three options based on the lowest cost, the most for money and the fewest stops. For example, if you plan a trip that looks something like Mumbai-Los Angeles-Bali-Bangkok-Kathmandu-Mumbai, your Lowest Cost results will show a stop over at Kuala Lumpur, while the Most for your Money will show you a lot more destinations that can be accommodated on your route by stretching your budget a little. The Fewest Stops list will just stick to your destination itinerary.

The approximate costs are given in dollars, and include only the air fare. The prices stated are as per current rates and booking the tickets online guarantees you 30 to 60 per cent off the published price.

Closer home, Traveljini ([| Planning Activities | Percentage |
|--------------------------------|------------|
| Destinations | 22% |
| Car rental prices/availability | 26% |
| Local events/calendars | 34% |
| Dining/entertainment | 38% |
| Air fares/itineraries | 45% |
| Activities | 46% |](http://www.travelji-</p>
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[ni.com](http://www.traveljini.com)) gives you more options for travel around our subcontinent, and is more suited to an outsider visiting India. It gives details about the destinations around the nation, listing the hotels available, the flights and trains that take you there. The site has hot deals on round trips to nearby destinations that are hard to ignore.

Traveljini also lets you plan for shorter trips and weekend getaways from your city of residence. It has trips planned for getaways within the reach of your residence, and lists them out with details on price per person and the duration of the trip. It also makes provisions for you to book online. The site also has the expected facilities of giving you the best air fares for destinations in and outside of India, and letting you book your tickets online.

In case you have a fixed destination in mind, or don't have much time on your hands, opt for package tours and lay back and let someone else do the running about. Package tours assure a hassle-free ferry between destinations, waving aside the worries of hotel reservations and ticket bookings. They are especially an advantage for an unfamiliar trip overseas where the comfort of a group and the assurance of safety are key drivers. Many reputed travel houses such as Cox and Kings (www.coxandkings.com), and Thomas Cook (www.thomascok.co.in) have special offers for tourists who book for the tours online.

While booking a tour, it is advisable to identify a source with a brick and mortar presence in your town. This way, you can be assured of offline assistance if required.

Thomas Cook, again, gives you the convenience of making your trip by giving you a list of options of destinations, airlines and hotels to choose from. But it also features package tours to different destinations. A worthy mention are the cruise packages that you can go on—you can choose from family cruises, honeymoon cruise, or those meant for singles—all classified by the region.

Info 84 per cent of online travel expenditures are for airline bookings

For the Vagabond Wanderer

If you've got the back packing itch, you might want to log on to Youth Hostels Association India at www.yhaindia.com. This functions on the lines of the YMCA—meaning if you avail of their membership for a nominal fee, you can stay in the hostels located all over India and abroad for as little as Rs 25 a day. You may, of course, be needed to help around the hostel a bit, but that just adds to the experience. They also organise regular short and long camps, and treks to various parts of the country. Other sites such as India Explorers (www.explorersindia.com) and India Outdoors

(www.indiaoutdoors.com) plan regular adventure trails such as rock climbing, rafting and Himalayan camps. The Bombay Natural History Society (www.bnhs.org) is another gold mine for trekkers.

Before you set out, you may want to prepare your self by reading up on the experiences of other trekkers. India Mike (www.indiamike.com) is a travel site relating hilarious and touching experiences of backpackers around India—some foreigners, some Indians and other in search of their roots. The site also has a forum and you can put up your experiences after you're back!

